

Team 10 Project Charter

1. Project Title:

Campus Dining Availability System

Project Information

Course: CS 4390 and CS 5388 Software Project Management

Date: September 2026

Current Stage: Validation through prototype evaluation

2. Project Decision and Evidence

Our team selected a real-time campus dining availability system after comparing five candidate ideas: food availability, dining hours and service status, meal-plan rollover, customizable meal plans, and dining alerts. The interviews showed repeated cases in which students expected an item or service to be available but learned about a change only after arriving.

The selected direction is to test a system that lets students check the current status of dining items, stations, kitchens, counters, and temporary service changes before walking to a location.

Evidence

Evidence group	Count	How it is used
Focused availability interviews	12	Primary evidence for the current project direction.
Meal-plan preference responses	13	Background from the earlier meal-plan direction. These responses do not validate the availability system.
Candidate ideas	5	Options compared before the team narrowed the project.

Examples from the focused interviews

- A cafe was open, but its kitchen had closed. The participant ordered delivery to the lab, spent about \$18, and waited roughly 40 minutes.
- An empty grab-and-go case led one participant to walk across campus for pizza. The detour took about 25 minutes.
- A participant found that the ribs were sold out, spent about \$6 extra on a snack, and waited until after class for a full meal.
- Students also reported sold-out soup, missing sandwiches, unavailable oat milk, cleared stations, and equipment or service changes.

The information was accurate in some interviews. Posted hours or menus sometimes matched what students found. The project is therefore focused on changes that normal hours and menu pages may not show, not on replacing information that already works.

3. Problem Statement and Business Objective

Problem statement

Students sometimes arrive at a campus dining location and discover that an item, station, kitchen service, counter, or required option is unavailable. When the information they checked beforehand does not show the change, they may lose time, substitute a meal, remain hungry, or spend more than planned.

First Business objective

Our first objective is to find out whether current information about dining items, stations, and services can help students avoid wasted trips, delays, substitutions, and unexpected spending when they decide where to eat on campus.

4. Scope Boundary

This phase covers research, requirements, and prototype evaluation. It does not include production deployment.

In scope	Out of scope	Deferred until later
Complete 13 additional focused availability interviews.	Launch a production website or mobile app.	Production application development.
Define functional and nonfunctional requirements.	Connect to live UTEP or vendor systems.	Live menu, inventory, or point-of-sale integrations.
Define statuses for items, stations, kitchens, counters, and outages.	Guarantee real-time or perfectly accurate information.	Push notifications and user accounts.
Design a practical update and verification workflow.	Change staffing, dining policy, meal-plan pricing, payment, or rollover rules.	Analytics, reporting dashboards, and role administration.
Create low-fidelity and interactive prototypes.	Replace official dining systems or begin a campus-wide rollout.	A limited pilot, followed by campus-wide implementation if approved.
Run usability tests and document feasibility findings.	Commit university staff or vendors to work they have not approved.	Operational ownership and service-level commitments.

5. Project Approach

Phase	Work	Output and decision
Validation	Conduct 13 more focused interviews using the same behavior-based method. Include different student types and dining locations.	Reach 25 focused availability interviews. Decide whether the problem is repeated, specific, and costly enough to continue.
Requirements	Rank the status changes students need, define update freshness, and identify who could report and verify each change.	Approved prototype requirements and a documented data workflow.

Phase	Work	Output and decision
Prototype	Create a low-fidelity flow, review it with the team, and build an interactive prototype for the main task.	A testable prototype that shows availability, location, status details, and when information was updated.
Usability and feasibility	Test the prototype with students and review operational limits with relevant stakeholders.	Usability findings, feasibility findings, and a recommendation to revise, pause, or prepare a pilot proposal.

Interview method

- Ask about recent behavior and specific dining experiences instead of asking whether someone likes the proposed system.
- Record what the participant expected, what was actually available, how they found out, what they did next, and the time or money involved.
- Record examples that do not support the project, including cases where the existing information was correct.
- Do not record a conversation without consent, and identify participants by a role or descriptor instead of a full name.

6. Assumptions and Dependencies

These statements are not proven facts. The team will test them before treating the project as feasible.

Assumption or dependency	How the team will check it
Students will check availability before walking to a dining location.	Ask about current checking behavior and test whether participants use the information in the prototype.
A small set of statuses will be clear enough to support a dining decision.	Test Available, Low Stock, Sold Out, Closed, and Service Outage labels during prototype sessions.
Availability can be updated often enough to remain useful.	Define an acceptable freshness target and identify the source and owner of each update.
Dining staff or another approved source can report changes without excessive work.	Map the shortest update workflow and review it with an operational stakeholder before a pilot is proposed.
Students from different groups experience the problem.	Include commuters, students living on campus, graduate students, and other frequent dining users in the next interviews.
The project can show stale or uncertain information honestly.	Prototype a visible last-updated time and a clear stale or unverified state.

7. Stakeholders and Team Responsibilities

Stakeholder	Interest or responsibility	Influence
Students	Use dining information and provide research and usability feedback.	High
Commuter students	May have limited time between classes and may be affected by unnecessary trips.	High
Students living on campus	May use campus dining often and encounter availability changes across several locations.	High
Graduate students	May have varied schedules and limited time to change dining plans.	Medium
Campus dining administration	Reviews operational feasibility, ownership, and the effect on staff work.	High
Dining locations and vendors	May supply or verify item, station, and service status information.	High
UTEP administration and technology teams	Would review policy, access, security, and integration needs before any pilot.	High
Team 10	Conducts research, defines requirements, builds the prototype, records decisions, and evaluates results.	High

Current team roles

Team member	Documented focus	Charter responsibility
Zachary Carrejo	Website and documentation	Maintain project documentation and present research and scope clearly.
Salvador Rodarte	Research and development	Support interviews, research synthesis, charter work, and prototype development.
Daniel Lozano	Database and development	Support requirements, data design, documentation, and technical development.
Jacob Ordonez	Website development	Support website and prototype development and help present dining information clearly.

Team 10 shares charter decisions. No project manager is assigned in the current source material.

8. Risks and Planned Responses

Risk	Why it matters	Planned response
Stale information	Incorrect status information could reduce trust and cause the same problems the project is meant to address.	Show when information was updated, define stale states, and test an escalation or verification path.
Staff workload	Frequent manual updates may not be practical during busy service periods.	Test the shortest possible update flow and compare manual, system, and shared reporting options.
No access to live systems	The team may not be able to use university or vendor data during this course phase.	Use realistic sample data for the prototype and document the integration questions that remain.
Research sample bias	A narrow participant group may overstate or miss parts of the problem.	Recruit across student types, schedules, and dining locations and use the same core interview questions.
Scope growth	Meal plans, notifications, payments, and production integrations could distract from the current question.	Use the scope boundary in this charter and record requested changes before adding work.
Unclear ownership	Availability information needs an approved source and someone responsible for corrections.	Do not recommend a pilot until the team documents who reports, verifies, and resolves disputed information.
Accessibility and privacy	A prototype that is hard to use or collects unnecessary personal information would exclude users or create risk.	Use readable status labels, keyboard-friendly interactions, color-independent cues, and minimal participant data.

9. Proposed Success Criteria and Stage Gates

The following targets guide future work. They are proposed project criteria, not findings from the completed interviews.

Gate	Proposed criterion	Decision
Research complete	Conduct 13 additional focused interviews, for 25 focused availability interviews in total. Keep meal-plan responses separate.	Continue only if repeated examples show a clear problem and consequence across independent conversations.
Requirements ready	Prioritize item, station, kitchen or counter, and outage statuses. Document the source, owner,	Proceed when the prototype requirements and update workflow are specific enough to test.

Gate	Proposed criterion	Decision
	freshness expectation, and stale-data behavior for each required status.	
Prototype ready	A student can select a location and identify whether an item or service is Available, Low Stock, Sold Out, Closed, or affected by a Service Outage. Every changing status shows when it was last updated or that it is stale or unverified.	Begin usability testing after the team completes an internal walkthrough with no blocking errors.
Usability reviewed	Test with at least five participants. At least four should complete the main availability-checking task without assistance.	Revise the prototype if the task result, wording, freshness, or navigation causes repeated confusion.
Feasibility reviewed	Document a realistic update owner, workflow, and data source before recommending a pilot.	Recommend a pilot proposal only if the operational path is credible and stakeholders have reviewed the open issues.

10. Governance and Open Decisions to Take

Decision process

Team 10 will review research findings and scope changes together because no project lead has been chosen and responsibility is being shared equally.

Open decisions

- Which changes are important enough to publish or notify?
- How quickly must each type of information be updated?
- Who can report and verify a change without adding excessive staff work?
- Should project value be measured mainly through time saved, cost avoided, or fewer disrupted meals?